secure them. And being proactive does not automatically imply strategic policy coherence. Partisanship and conciliation may not be intellectual choices that Indian officials imbibe and implement at a time of their choosing. But their robust existence highlights a preference for different tools of diplomacy and statecraft to attain the larger strategic goal of a stable, sovereign, friendly, and territorially united Afghanistan.

The one strategic constant within this mosaic of divergent policies approaches, then, has been India's insatiable search for 'friends' in Afghanistan. These friends are people or groups, preferably official but also unofficial, who are expected to be sensitive to India's national interests in and around Afghanistan. These friends are expected to appreciate India's diversity and may count upon New Delhi to occasionally support and advocate their cause internationally. Just like India's ever-changing notions of national interest, however, the Afghan cause could also be anything. It could be a request to develop infrastructure, offer financial assistance, support Afghanistan on international forums, or help these Afghan friends fight their political and military battles both inside and outside that country. Whatever the time period may be, and whoever the ruler, India has always sought such friendly relationships in Afghanistan (as it has, quite unsurprisingly, with most of the world). Whilst the nature of such relationships was hierarchical or marked by dependency during the British Raj, the partition of the subcontinent in 1947 changed the dynamic.[15] The new state of Pakistan (which allegedly carried forward the legacy of the British Raj vis-à-vis Afghanistan) stood as a geographical wedge between India and Afghanistan. This geographical wedge, arguably, unshackled India from its need and/or desires to exert influence on, or solve bilateral disputes with Afghanistan (a strategic aspect reserved for other smaller neighbours, with whom India has territorial boundaries). As an Indian analyst noted, India's geographical disconnect became its primary weakness but also its cardinal strength in Afghanistan.[16] Conversely, the 2,250-odd kilometers long open border became Pakistan's biggest strength as well as its principal weakness with Afghanistan.

Seeking such friends, at first, was easy for New Delhi and politically uncomplicated for Kabul. The 1950 Treaty of Friendship between the two countries marked the first official step in this direction.[17] A stable, sovereign, and